

PAA to Pariah

As the Congress distances itself from the Bachchans at two public functions, Bollywood's biggest icon pays a high price for a seemingly apolitical endorsement of Gujarat

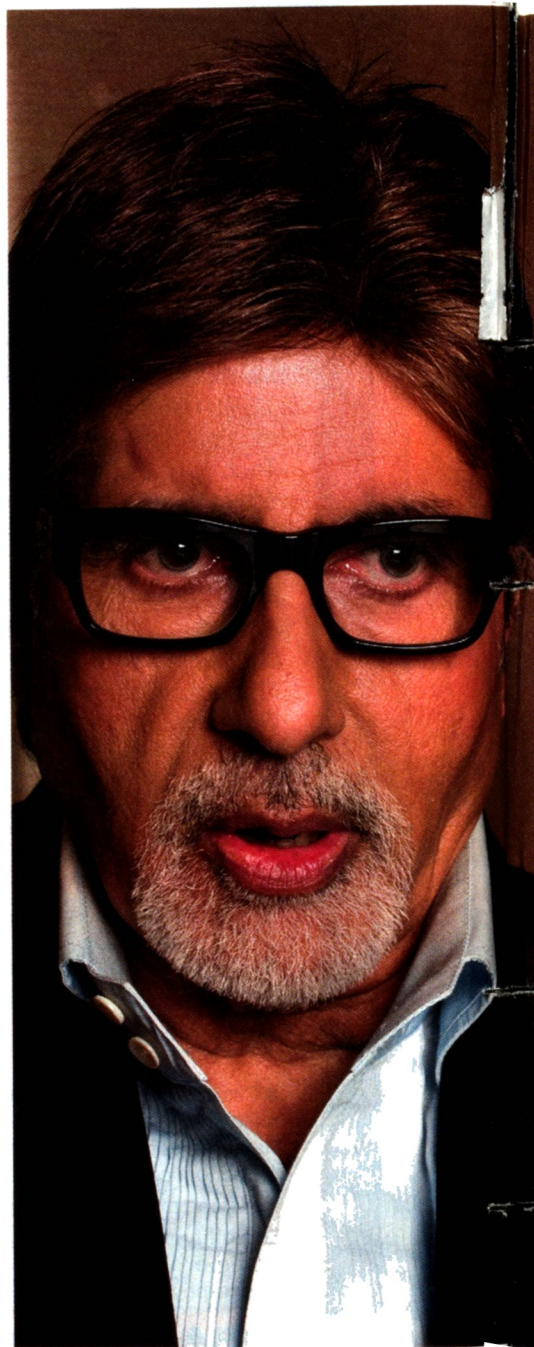
| By Kaveree Bamzai |

When did Amitabh Bachchan go from Paa to pariah? When did Bollywood's first family become a farce family, seemingly caught in the wrong place at the wrong time in the wrong company? When did a national icon become a subject of open Congress scorn?

Whether it was Bachchan's presence at the inauguration of the Bandra-Worli sea link in Mumbai after which Chief Minister Ashok Chavan tried to shake off association with him or son Abhishek's posters and video message being mysteriously absent from a function in Delhi where Sheila Dikshit was chief guest, the media pounced on what seemed to be a delicious combination of political skullduggery and Bollywood drama. It

was enough to send Bachchan to his favourite pulpit, his blog; Modi to his favourite pastime, of calling others names they call him, in this case, the Taliban; Abhishek Manu Singhvi to his favourite evening exercise, defending the Congress on a succession of TV channels; and everyone with a taste for trivia into exhuming the once gilded relationship between the Bachchans and the Gandhis, with the eternal question, what went wrong?

Bachchan is not new to being made to feel unwelcome by the UPA Government. It has happened before when he was invited to be chief guest at the International Film Festival of India in 2005 by the Goa chief minister and then immediately disinvited by the Ministry of Information and Broadcasting. Since an outburst in 2004 from Rahul Gandhi in response to Jaya Bachchan's remark that



"I don't think the Samajwadi Party has changed but Amar Singh not being in the party is felt. But I am on very good terms with him."

JAYA BACHCHAN



"Jayaji, I want to tell you that your brother-in-law was insulted. I want to tell you that Manoj Tiwari and Jaya Prada are with me."

AMAR SINGH